

The Rules Of Engagement

The winner will need to (these are in no particular order):

1. Prove it's hardware-worthy

The PS2 is going strong even today for the simple reason that it's still possible to create good-looking and complex games for that hardware which won't turn it into a brick. A console's hardware must be future-proof, and provide gaming joy for years to come.

2. Not bankrupt you

If you think your monetary woes end with just buying a console, think again...

3. Be in tune with the Force

This is the most intangible part—the experience. Will it rock your Casbah? Does it have Mojo? Will it bake you cookies when you're depressed?

In the first corner, we have the reigning champion of the market, M-Dollar's favourite child after Vista itself, please welcome...

The Xbox 360

(We reviewed the Xbox 360 back in August 2006, so this will be somewhat short.)

It must be nice to lead the life of the Xbox 360—take the market over just by virtue of *existing*, and while your closest competitor takes a year to release, spread your word far and wide to everyone who'll spare you twenty seconds of their time. Not that the 360 doesn't deserve to be at the top.

Powerhouse

With a tri-core IBM CPU and an ATI-built GPU at its heart, the Xbox 360 is capable of incredible visual detail and excellent physics. See the *In A Nutshell* table for more on the 360's innards; you'll see why we still haven't seen a game that the 360 has trouble handling.

In the HD department, the 360 supports up to 1080i—one step lower than the PS3's 1080p—but it has a neat trick up its sleeve, and it's called Ana. Ana is a chip that scales game resolutions up to the maximum that the TV is capable of. Play a 720p game or movie on a TV that's capable of 1080p, and you'll see the Xbox 360 scaling up to that resolution. To most eyes, however, the difference between regular TV and 720p can be summed up as, "This is waaaaay better"; the difference between 720p and 1080p is just barely perceptible, and even then, only because you know it's there. Ana's benefits will become clearer some time in the future, when all we see is HD content.

The Adventures Of The Wallet

You can get yourself the Xbox 360 Premium System for Rs 23,000, and

this is the one we recommend. It comes with a wireless controller and a Media Center-esque remote, and most importantly, it comes with component cables for your HDTV. Good quality component cables are hard to find, and when you do, they're painfully expensive. If you've got an HDTV, this is a godsend.

Speaking of HDTVs, the 360 is wasted on anything but. On a regular old TV, the most that can be said about the 360's graphics is that they are significantly better than the PS2's. So when you buy your 360, make sure you're building up another Rs 30,000 or so for a decent HDTV. Titles come at nearly Rs 3,000 apiece, so this is going to pinch a bit too.

Going Online

You get a trial membership for Xbox Live when you buy your 360, but Xbox Live has yet to officially launch in India—this should happen later this year. You can still access Live, however—browse content, download game demos and so on, but you're banned instantly when you try to enter the Video section. Most importantly, you can play your games online. With our current broadband situation, though, Live will have a limited Indian audience.

There are plenty of nice things to be said about the Xbox 360, but there's trouble brewing... or is it?

The Sony PlayStation 3

Thanks to plenty of media hype and CEO Ken Kutaragi's obnoxious jingoism, the PS3 seems to have acquired legendary status well before its time—its very presence inspires awe. The design of the console itself oozes style, and yes, that shiny exterior is just begging for fingerprints. Put it next to a sizeable HDTV, and your view of the PS3 is more realistic. It's not a Formidable Force™, it's just a big console.

Roaring Engines

The PS3 is powered by the Sony-Toshiba-IBM (STI) Cell Broadband Engine, or the Cell processor as it's popularly known. This processing behemoth sports a single PowerPC core, helped along by a team of eight Synergistic Processing Elements (SPEs), one of which has been reserved for redundancy. Paired with NVIDIA's RSX GPU, the system is theoretically capable of nearly two teraflops (floating-point operations per second)—nearly double the overall capability of the Xbox 360. In terms of raw specifications, then, the PS3 leaves the Xbox 360 in the dust—no worrying about game developers running out of power on this one. If anything, the biggest challenge they'll face is making a game that will truly exploit the power of the Cell, complete with ultra-realistic graphics and insanely complex AI.

Coming Soon To A Console Near You

When you fire up a title for the PS3, it undoubtedly looks amazing, but one question niggles—what is this doing that the 360 isn't? Today, that answer is "nothing." Whether the PS3 looks better than the 360 is a subjective matter, but while you sit and expect to be blown away by something that is technologically superior to the 360, all you find is something that is at par, if not marginally worse (no hardware scaling chip, remember?).

Read on for our views a couple of launch titles later in this issue, but first...

Lost In Space

When you first pick up the PS3's new wireless SIXAXIS controller, it feels, well, cheap—almost like a bootleg PS2 controller. The vibration is gone, making the controller lighter, but this may not be as good as it sounds—we were to find this out later. The controller is also motion sensitive, so you can control games by tilting it in the right direction. In the

